3.5 Legacy of the War

With the war finally over, the young country assessed its costs and looked toward the future. The citizens of the United States had some hard decisions to make. What direction would the new country take?

MAIN IDEA Once a formal treaty was negotiated and signed, the United States began to forge its new identity as an independent nation.

NEGOTIATING THE PEACE

The American Revolution was over. It would soon inspire other nations, including France and the French colony of Haiti, to revolt and demand democracy. But war always comes at a high price. Thousands of soldiers—both American and British—lost their lives in combat, and even more died of disease. Now it was time to heal and begin building the nation. First, though, the United States and Great Britain had to make peace. The two countries did so in the **Treaty of Paris of 1783**.

Benjamin Franklin, John Jay, and John Adams negotiated skillfully for the United States. The treaty they produced included two extremely important **provisions**, or legal conditions, that aided the country. The British agreed both to recognize the independence of the United States of America and to approve the new American boundaries. The new country was bounded on the west by the Mississippi River, on the north by Canada, and on the south by Florida. The United States would have plenty of growing room.

Florida, from which Britain had created **East Florida** and **West Florida**, went back to Spain in a separate agreement. The British also made a separate agreement with France over parts of the West Indies and Canada.

A NEW IDENTITY

Not all Americans were happy with the outcome of the war. Many Loyalists and Native Americans, furious that their British allies had signed away their lands, moved to Canada. Some former slaves freed by the British also made their way to Canada, but others were returned to slavery. The majority of Americans, though, stayed right where they were and began rebuilding. Britain's economic control and taxation had spurred the Revolution. Freedom of trade took firm hold, laying the groundwork for growing commerce and industry.

Liberty and equality were central to the new national identity as well. In 1781, an enslaved woman named Mum Betts sued and won her freedom in court. Taking the name **Elizabeth Freeman**, she inspired Massachusetts to become the first state to abolish slavery. In Delaware, **Richard Allen** bought his freedom and later founded one of the first independent black churches in Philadelphia.

The most difficult task facing the United States was establishing a plan for government. Citizens favored **republicanism**, a system with no king or queen, where the people choose representatives to make their laws. They also stressed civic republicanism, or responsibility for the common good. Americans hoped to blend civic republicanism and ideals of classical liberal principles, including private property and individual and religious freedoms, to create their new government.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did the Treaty of Paris of 1783 secure the future of the United States?
2. **DESCRIBE** How did the U.S. government plan reflect the ideals of civic republicanism, classical liberal principles, and English parliamentary traditions?
3. **FORM AND SUPPORT OPINIONS** Do you think African Americans were better off after the revolution? Explain why or why not.

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The solemn Ratifications of the present Treaty expedited in
good and due Form shall be exchanged between the contracting
Parties in the Space of Six Months or sooner if possible, to be
computed from the Day of the Signature of the Present Treaty.
In Witness whereof We the undersigned, their Ministers
Plenipotentiary, have in their Name and in Virtue of our
full Powers, signed with our Hands the present Definitive
Treaty, and caused the Seals of our Arms to be affixed thereto.

Done at Paris, this third Day of September
In the Year of our Lord, one thousand, seven hundred
and Eighty three. —

D Hartley

John Adams.

B Franklin

John Jay



CRITICAL VIEWING As David Hartley of Great Britain and John Adams, Benjamin Franklin, and John Jay of the United States signed the Treaty of Paris, shown here, each man added his wax seal—the red patch to the left of each name. The seal was made by dripping melted wax onto a surface and pressing a personalized metal stamp into the wax before it cooled. In the 18th century, a wax seal confirmed the identity of the signer of a document. Why might a personalized seal have been required on a document like this one?

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